Naga Council (UNC) jointly demanded an NRC and a State Population Commission. The Manipur assembly passed a resolution supporting both in August 2022 and reaffirmed its NRC demand in March 2024. The assembly again backed an NRC before the Census this September.

In July, Naga and Meitei organisations demonstrated together demanding that the 'suspension of operations' agreement with Kuki militant groups be scrapped. In August, the UNC again joined Meitei organisations in insisting on an NRC before either the Census or delimitation. "A census before citizenship verification risks putting non-citizens into Manipur's demographic record," says UNC president Ng. Lorho. "The NRC must come first, especially when continuing conflict and unresolved territorial disputes already make a credible Census difficult."

The argument over Census 2027 shows why demographic data has become so politically sensitive. A Census does not determine citizenship. It counts the population living in an area, including people who may be non-citizens. The NRC, by contrast, intends to identify citizens. Meitei and Naga groups want the 1951 Census as the NRC benchmark. Home minister Govindas Konthoujam also told the assembly on September 7 that the state favours 1951.

The Kuki-Zo Council objects on both practical and political grounds. It argues that many hill areas in 1951 were remote, poorly connected and inadequately documented. Using those records could exclude families whose presence in Manipur predates the cut-off but whose documentary trail does not. The fact that Kuki, Chin and Zomi populations historically straddle the border with Myanmar makes documentary ancestry contentious. Also, after the February 2021 military coup in Myanmar, the porous border saw many refugees entering Manipur. Ginza Vualzong, secretary, information & publicity, Kuki-Zo Council, the apex body of the communities, though, sees a conspiracy. "The demand for an NRC before the Census is being driven by unfounded allegations about the Kuki-Zo population. Let the Census establish the demographic facts first. Citizenship can't be decided by communal suspicion, nor can any state or community dictate an NRC," he says.

> **"A Census before citizenship verification risks adding non-citizens into Manipur's demographic record. The NRC must come first, especially now with the current disputes"**
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> **NG. LORHO,** *President, United Naga Council*

> **"The 'NRC before the Census' demand is driven by unfounded allegations about the Kuki-Zo. Let the Census establish the demographic facts first. Citizenship can't be decided by communal suspicion...no one can dictate an NRC"**
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> **GINZA VUALZONG**
> *Secretary, Information & Publicity, Kuki-Zo Council*

The ethnic divide has also reached the government. On September 10, Naga deputy CM Losii Dikho boycotted a cabinet meeting because fellow deputy CM Nemcha Kipgen, a Kuki, was attending. The UNC has made Kipgen's removal a principal demand.

Delimitation raises the stakes further. Manipur has 60 assembly seats, 40 in the valley and 20 in the hills. The existing configuration dates back to the 1973 delimitation based on the 1971 Census. A later delimitation based on the 2001 Census was not implemented amid disputes over population figures. A fresh Census could then alter the distribution of political representation between the valley and the hills.

THE POLITICS OF POPPY

The allegation that Kuki-dominated areas are centres of illegal poppy cultivation has been around since before the 2023 violence. The latest destruction figures, however, make a purely ethnic reading difficult. Between January 1 and February 28, authorities destroyed 957 hectares of poppy across seven Manipur districts. The largest area was not in Kuki-Zo-dominated Kangpokpi or Churachandpur but in Naga-majority Ukhrul, where 634 ha. were destroyed. Kangpokpi accounted for 98 ha. and Churachandpur 94 ha. Longer-term figures present a more mixed picture. Government data from 2024 showed Kangpokpi recording the highest cumulative destruction since 2017, followed by Ukhrul and Churachandpur.

The numbers are significant because they show that poppy cultivation is a hill-wide criminal and livelihood economy rather than a phenomenon that can be pinned on one community. Manipur borders Myanmar and lies close to the larger Golden Triangle narcotics economy. Armed organisations, smugglers and local networks have long competed over routes, protection money and border trade.

Manipur's danger is no longer one ethnic war but a chain of overlapping conflicts in which citizenship, land, drugs and political representation reinforce one another. Unless the state restores control over arms, settles competing territorial claims and separates citizenship from ethnicity, every new dispute risks reopening an old wound again. ■